

Staff Cost Scenario Planner

Business Case — Internal Tool Deployment · FY 2025–
26

Date: May 2026

Status: For Review & Approval

Classification: Internal

NI operates across 11 country offices and headquarters in Ottawa. There is currently no shared tool for estimating the true cost of a staff position — managers submit budget requests based on base salary alone, systematically omitting statutory employer contributions (8–28% depending on country), replacement costs, and leave liability. The result is recurring budget shortfalls, rework between HR and Finance, and delayed hiring decisions.

The **NI Staff Cost Scenario Planner** is a ready-to-deploy, browser-based tool that delivers band-accurate employment cost, replacement cost, and leave cost modelling across all NI locations — in under 60 seconds, with no spreadsheet required.

THE PROBLEM

- No consistent method for estimating total employment cost across NI's 11 locations — managers use base salary only, leaving employer burden unbudgeted
- Replacement costs (averaging 40–70% of annual salary) are routinely absent from position requests, surfacing as a Finance correction after approval
- Leave cost modelling (maternity, medical, extended) is rebuilt manually by HR and Finance for each request, with no standard assumptions
- NI's official salary bands — Canada Band 1–10 and Birches Group BG-05 to BG-13 — are not embedded in any planning tool; out-of-band offers

SCALE



PROGRAMS UNIT CONTEXT

"Programs teams have been asking for a simple way to model the cost of a position before we raise it with Finance. We spend more time justifying numbers than we do planning the actual program."

**PROGRAMS & COUNTRY OFFICE FEEDBACK
— P&C FY2026 PLANNING CYCLE**

Programs is NI's largest employer of country-office staff. Country Directors and Program Managers must model hypothetical positions for donor proposals and budget submissions before engaging Finance — a process that today produces inconsistent estimates and creates rework for all three functions.

go undetected until the offer stage

- Cross-location comparisons require multi-day coordination between Country Offices, HR, and Finance before a single number is confirmed

USE CASE SCENARIOS

HIRING

Manager · HR
BP · Finance

New Position Budget Request

A program manager in Ethiopia selects BG-09 in the band picker. The tool instantly returns base salary (ETB + USD), CPF contributions, benefits loading, and total annual employment cost — ready to paste into the budget submission. No HR or Finance involvement required at this stage.

REPLACEMENT

HR BP
·
Country
Director

Resignation Backfill Decision

A Country Director receives a resignation. The Replacement Cost tab models recruitment agency fees, advertising, interview hours, onboarding cost, and the full ramp-up productivity gap — giving Finance a defensible total before a backfill decision is tabled at EXCOM.

LEAVE PLANNING

HR BP ·
Finance BP

Maternity / Medical Leave Budget

HR models a 17-week maternity leave in Canada: gross pay, government benefit recovery (55%), net employer cost, and optional backfill daily rate. Finance receives a single agreed number for the mid-year forecast rather than a bespoke manual estimate.

PROPOSAL COSTING

Programs ·
Country
Office

Donor Proposal Staff Budget

A Programs Officer building a USAID proposal for Senegal models three proposed positions using the official BG bands. The employer burden and benefits loading are automatically applied, ensuring the proposal budget aligns with NI's actual cost structure — reducing revision cycles with Finance.

LOCATION COMPARE

Sr.
Management
· HR

Strategic Workforce Decision

A VP assessing where to locate a new regional role uses the Compare tab to view employment cost, replacement cost, and leave cost side-by-side across six country offices in a single view — a comparison that previously took two to three days of back-and-forth to produce.

BAND COMPLIANCE

HR BP ·
Compensation

Offer Letter Review

Before extending an offer, HR enters the proposed salary for a Band 6 role in Ottawa. The compa-ratio and band position bar instantly flag whether the number is within range, at risk of compression, or outside band — without opening the Salary Admin Guidelines DOCX on SharePoint.

EFFICIENCIES CREATED

ACTIVITY	CURRENT EFFORT	WITH PLANNER	TIME SAVED	ANNUAL VOLUME
New position employment cost estimate	2–3 hrs (HR + Finance)	<5 min (self-serve)	~2.5 hrs / request	~60–80 positions
Replacement cost modelling	3–4 hrs (HR + Finance)	<10 min	~3.5 hrs / event	~20–30 resignations
Leave cost estimate (maternity / medical)	1–2 hrs (HR + Finance)	<5 min	~1.5 hrs / case	~15–20 cases
Cross-location cost comparison	1–2 days (HR + CO coordination)	<15 min	~10 hrs / comparison	~10–15 requests
Donor proposal staff costing (Programs)	4–6 hrs (Programs + HR + Finance)	<30 min	~5 hrs / proposal	~20–25 proposals
Estimated total annual hours reclaimed (conservative)			400–650 hours across HR, Finance & Programs	

RECOMMENDATION Approve immediate deployment of the NI Staff Cost Scenario Planner to all HR Business Partners, Finance Business Partners, Country Directors, and Program Managers via the P&C SharePoint intranet and the existing HR portal. Establish a **quarterly update cycle** aligned to Birches Group data releases. Prioritize access for Programs ahead of the FY2026–27 donor proposal season. Implementation cost: **nil** — the tool is deployed and live.